The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Iran's foreign minister, Abbas Araghchi, held talks with the International Atomic Energy Agency, the UN's nuclear watchdog, about his country's nuclear programme ahead of negotiations with American officials in Geneva on Tuesday. America has deployed a second aircraft-carrier to the Middle East, putting more pressure on Iran, while Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, called for "all enriched material" to "leave Iran".

Marco Rubio, America's secretary of state, endorsed Hungary's prime minister, **Viktor Orban**, ahead of the country's parliamentary elections on April 12th. Mr Rubio said President Trump is "deeply committed" to Mr Orban's success and pledged financial support for the populist-right leader. Mr Orban's Fidesz party is trailing in the polls behind the Tisza party of Peter Magyar, a former ally-turned-critic.

Russia denied it poisoned **Alexei Navalny** with a toxin found in a South American frog. The opposition leader died two years ago in a Russian prison. "We do not accept such accusations," a spokesperson for President Vladimir Putin said. Epibatidine was "highly likely the cause of his death", according to a joint

statement by Britain, France, Germany, the Netherlands and Sweden published last weekend.

Ed Miliband, Britain's energy secretary, and **Gavin Newsom**, California's Democratic governor, signed a clean-energy partnership, promising to share technology and attract joint investment. Octopus Energy, a British green-power group, pledged to invest $1bn in Californian renewables, storage and carbon-removal projects. Donald Trump, who has loosened America's greenhouse-gas regulations, criticised the pact as "inappropriate" and urged Britain not to "get involved" with Mr Newsom.

The **Federal Reserve** plans to relax capital rules for American banks to encourage more mortgage lending, Michelle Bowman, its vice-chair for supervision, said. The changes would let banks adjust the capital they hold to reflect a loan's risk, rather than apply a single standard for all mortgages. Officials argue that strict rules have pushed activity to non-bank lenders.

Hapag-Lloyd, the world's fifth-largest container-shipping group, agreed to buy ZIM, an **Israeli** competitor, for $4.2bn. Carriers ordered record numbers of ships during the pandemic, but freight rates have now slumped and the industry is consolidating. Staff at ZIM went on strike to oppose the merger with the German company and Israeli officials raised national-security concerns. Israel's competition authority will review the deal.

Robert Duvall, an American actor who played roles in "The Godfather", "To Kill a Mockingbird" and "Apocalypse Now", died aged 95. His wife said he passed away "peacefully" at his home in Virginia. Known for meticulous preparation and the variety of characters he portrayed, he won an Academy Award for "Tender Mercies" and received seven Oscar nominations during a career spanning more than six decades.

Figure of the day: 9m square kilometres, all that remains of the jaguar's original range. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

European industry’s bumpy recovery

As China’s firms rise, Europe’s policymakers have been fretting over how to boost the European Union’s competitiveness. One plan is to give the European Commission, the EU’s executive arm, a mandate to propose reforms to capital and energy markets. Another suggestion is to add “Buy European” clauses to a bill that is expected to be revealed next week and is designed to beef up the bloc’s industries.

The latest production figures, released on Monday, might seem to support those fears. They show that industrial output for December fell by 1.4% in the euro area and by 0.8% in the EU compared with November. But the end-of-year setback comes after several months of growth, and production in December 2025 was still higher than it had been a year previously. Firms are increasingly optimistic, according to sentiment surveys. Those numbers suggest that European leaders should not embrace protectionism quite yet.

Photograph: Getty Images

Sir Keir’s umpteenth reset

Sir Keir Starmer’s leadership crisis has claimed another victim. First the prime minister’s chief of staff, Morgan McSweeney, resigned on February 8th over his advice to appoint Peter Mandelson as Britain’s ambassador to America, despite the grandee’s ties to Jeffrey Epstein. The next day his director of communications, Tim Allan, followed. Now Sir Chris Wormald, the cabinet secretary, who advises the prime minister on the workings of government, has been forced out. He barely lasted a year.

Sir Keir, the most unpopular prime minister ever, is safe, for now. His clear-out of senior staff is an attempt to reboot his premiership for the umpteenth time. He is at the mercy of Labour’s soft-left MPs. To prevent a coup, the prime minister will probably double down on progressive legislation, such as labour laws that are a throwback to the 1970s. Harder problems, such as soaring welfare spending, will have to wait for another day.

Photograph: Getty Images

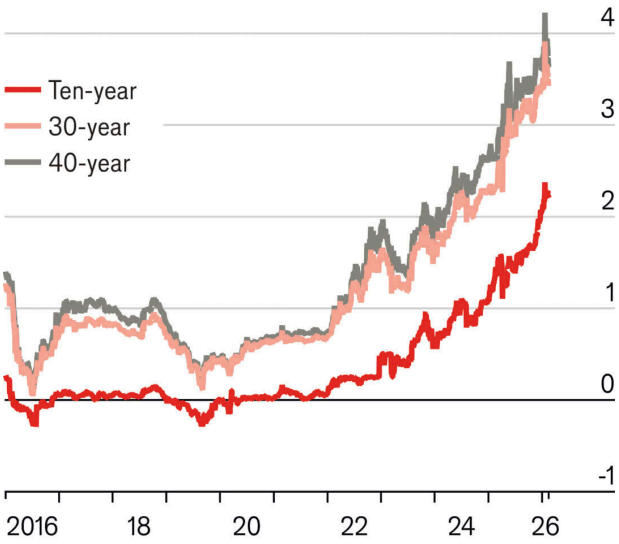
Can Takaichi Sanae balance the books?

Japan's economy grew by an annualised 0.2% in the fourth quarter of 2025, according to preliminary data released on Monday. Though an improvement over the previous quarter, when GDP contracted, the new figure is far lower than what analysts had expected. Private consumption, which accounts for more than half of GDP, grew by just 0.1%. Household finances remain under strain; real wages fell by 1.3% in 2025.

Takaichi Sanae, the prime minister, wants to use fiscal policy to boost growth. She plans to spend in order to strengthen supply chains. And she wants to suspend an 8% sales tax on food for two years, potentially forgoing ¥10 trillion ($64bn). Keenly aware that Japan's debt is already 130% of GDP, Ms Takaichi says no new bonds will be issued to cover costs. Investors are sceptical. Yields rose before a snap election on February 8th, then stabilised. Having won a supermajority, Ms Takaichi has a strong mandate. Making the sums work will test it.

Tenors and tremors

Japan, government-bond yields, %



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Getty Images

Vietnam’s leader visits America

Fresh off a victory over factional rivals in Vietnam’s most recent Communist Party congress, To Lam, the party’s general secretary, is expected to travel to America this week to attend the first meeting of President Donald Trump’s “Board of Peace”.

Vietnam’s inclusion among the board’s founding members was a surprise. Rumours that Mr Lam hopes to meet Mr Trump to discuss trade may explain it. America’s third-largest trade deficit, worth $124bn, is with Vietnam. Its goods face a 20% tariff. “Transshipped” goods, the definition of which remains unclear, are subject to a 40% tax. A sixth round of talks with America earlier this month ended without a resolution.

Vietnam’s peculiar history with the United Nations, which American officials claim the board may replace, could also play a role: Vietnam has been invaded by four of the five permanent members of the UN Security Council.

Photograph: Getty Images

The real cost of rice

Food production is the world's second largest emitter of greenhouse gas after making energy, contributing to almost 12% of the world's total output. Growing crops accounts for a quarter of this. Researchers at Cornell University have now mapped these emissions by food type, allowing policymakers to assess which might be worth the environmental cost given the calories they produce.

Their study, published in *Nature Climate Change*, shows that rice, maize, oil palm and wheat account for two-thirds of crops' emissions. Part of this is explained by the ubiquity of these four staples. But rice and palm-oil production are particularly polluting compared with the other two. Rice alone is responsible for 43% of gas produced. Yet while paddies belch methane, rice fills bellies. Palm-oil production pumps out carbon but contributes less to diets. Fruits and vegetables are energy-dense and less polluting. The map, the authors argue, could help cut agricultural emissions.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: What colour, traditionally worn by a cardinal, is also associated with a childhood disease?

You’re not allowed to give up.

Alexei Navalny